by the weavers to escape famines and seek greener, or more aptly, silkier pastures. Weavers in south India belong to specific communities with a long history of migrations such as the Kaikkolar, Saliyar, Devanga, Jedara or Pattunulkarar, the last also known as the Saurashtrar—the largest group of weaver migrants in the Vijayanagar and post-Vijayanagar periods, concentrated in Madurai.[66] They can trace their origins to an inscription in Mandasor in the Malwa region of Madhya Pradesh in the late 5th century CE. The Mandasor inscription stated that Brahmin silk weavers migrated as a group from a region in Gujarat into Mandasor, or Dasapura, around the 3rd or 4th centuries CE, providing a clue as to why they may be called the Sourashtrar. Subsequent migrations are preserved in oral traditions called *boula*, a unique question and answer session between the parties of the bride and groom at every Saurashtra wedding. A sample translated dialogue from the boula is as follows:[67]

> *Kay naa meneti* [What I mean to say is]
>
> ‘When we glance at the history of immigration of our ancestors from times immemorial, they lived in a far-off northern direction, in a region called Saurashtra. In that district, they lived in the town of Devagiri.
>
> ‘What I mean is, our gotra is . . .
> Our country is Saurashtra,
> Our town is Devagiri,
> Our religion is the Vaishnava religion,
> Our varna is the Gauda-Brahmin varna,
> If you ask to which they proceeded
> They came to Madurai . . .’

The other party would also begin with the first line and refer to a similar migration route. The ritual ended after an exchange of *tamboolam* and a concluding ceremony with people dressed in the silks for which they had acquired much fame.

Weaver migrations in medieval south India could involve distances of over a 1000 km staggered, at the community level, over centuries, and were usually permanent migrations of entire families. The language of the